

Penal Substitution

doc-penal-substitution

Soteriology · Atonement · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Christ's atoning death includes bearing God's judgment against sin in the place of sinners (penal-substitutionary aspect).

In plain language

The question asks whether the death of Jesus, as the Bible describes it, includes him taking the place of sinners and bearing the judgment their sin deserved. The original-language words point firmly in that direction. Isaiah 53 verse 5 says he was pierced because of our 'transgressions' (pesha) and 'crushed' (daka) because of our 'iniquities' (avon), and that the 'chastisement' or corrective discipline (musar) of our peace was upon him. The little 'from' prefix (the min prefix) on those sin words means 'on account of', so the suffering is for what others did. Verse 6 says the LORD himself laid on him the 'iniquity' (avon) of us all. Verse 10 says it 'pleased' (chaphets) the LORD to crush him and made his life a 'guilt offering' (asham), the same sacrificial word used through Leviticus. In the New Testament a tight cluster of words carries the same idea. Romans 3 verse 25 calls Jesus the 'place of atonement' (hilasterion), using the very word used for the blood-sprinkled mercy seat in Hebrews 9 verse 5, and the next verse says the aim was that God be just and also the one who declares sinners right. First John twice calls him the 'means of atonement' (hilasmos) for our sins, and Hebrews says he came to 'make propitiation' (hilaskomai, to turn away wrath) for the sins of the people. Galatians 3 verse 13 says he became a 'curse' (katara) for us, quoting the law that anyone hanged on a tree is cursed. Two threads run together, substitution in the words 'for us' (huper hemon) and 'concerning our sins' (peri), and the bearing of judgment in the guilt offering, the crushing, the mercy seat, and the curse. There is one honest soft spot. The atonement word group can be read either as turning away anger or as cleansing sin, because it can name a place or object. The cleansing reading is real, but the same verb 'be propitiated' (hilaskomai) in Luke 18 verse 13 is a plea for God to be appeased, which tips the balance toward the fuller sense. First John 4 verse 10 anchors all of this in God's love. The evidence spans the law, the prophets, and several letters, so the verdict is affirmed with high confidence.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0817	אָשָׁם	asham	guilt (offering)	43
H1792	דָּכָא	daka	to crush	20
H2654	חָפֵץ	chaphets	to delight in	71
H2656	חֶפֶץ	chephets	pleasure	
H3727	כַּפֹּרֶת	kapporet	mercy seat	27
H4148	מוֹסֵר	musar	discipline	50
H5771	עָוֹן	avon	iniquity	215
H6588	פֶּשַׁע	pesha	transgression	85

G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapaō	to love	
G0265	ἁμάρτημα	hamartema	sin	5
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0749	ἄρχιερεύς	archiereus	high-priest	
G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	
G1344	δικαιόω	dikaioō	to justify	
G1805	ἐξαγοράζω	exagorazo	to redeem	5
G1944	ἐπικατάρατος	epikataratos	cursed	2
G2433	ἱλάσκομαι	hilaskomai	to propitiate	2
G2434	ἱλασμός	hilasmos	propitiation	2
G2435	ἱλαστήριον	hilasterion	propitiation	2
G2671	κατάρα	katara	curse	6

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Two threads run together across both testaments and both can be checked in the queried canon. Substitution is carried by small words, 'for us' (huper hemon) in Galatians 3:13 and 'concerning our sins' (peri ton hamarton hemon) in 1 John 2:2 and 1 John 4:10, plus the LORD laying the 'iniquity' (avon, H5771) of all on the Servant in Isaiah 53:6. The penal element is carried by Isaiah 53:5 and 53:10, where the Servant is 'crushed' (daka, H1792) for our 'transgressions' (pesha, H6588) and iniquities (avon, H5771), bears the 'chastisement' (musar, H4148) of our peace, is made a 'guilt offering' (asham, H0817, a term that occurs 43 times and clusters in the Levitical sacrificial law), and is crushed because it 'pleased' (chaphets, H2654) the LORD. In the New Testament the 'atonement' (hilasmos) word group (G2434, G2435, G2433) ties his death to the 'mercy seat' (hilasterion, G2435) in Romans 3:25, the same noun used literally for the mercy seat in Hebrews 9:5, and is set in the frame of God being just and the justifier (Romans 3:26). Galatians 3:13 says he became a 'curse' (katara, G2671) for us, citing the legal sentence of Deuteronomy 21:23. Both substitution and the bearing of judgment are lexically present (visible at the word level), so the proposition is affirmed. The one genuine lexical crux (the hardest word-level puzzle), whether the 'atonement' (hilasmos) group means wrath-averting propitiation (turning away divine anger) or sin-cleansing expiation (washing away sin), is resolved toward the wrath-related sense by Luke 18:13, where the same verb 'be propitiated' (hilaskomai) is a plea to God to be appeased, but the alternative gloss remains lexically real, which is why this is noted rather than hidden.

Scripture

Isa.53.5 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H1792 דָּכָא; H4148 מוֹסֵר, H6588 פֶּשַׁע; H5771 עוֹן.

Reasoning. The Servant is pierced because of our 'transgressions' (pesha, H6588) and 'crushed' (daka, H1792) because of our 'iniquities' (avon, H5771), and the 'chastisement' (musar, H4148, meaning corrective discipline) of our peace was upon him. The 'from' prefix (the min prefix) on the sin words is causal (it carries an 'on account of' meaning), the suffering is on account of others' sin, and 'chastisement' (musar) across its 50 occurrences carries the sense of corrective discipline or chastisement, which supplies the penalty term that the prior file did not record. The substitution and the penal weight (the bearing of judgment) are both stated in one verse.

Isa.53.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H5771 יָנַח,

Reasoning. The LORD is the explicit subject who caused to fall on him the 'iniquity' (avon, H5771) of us all. The verb has YHWH (the LORD) as agent and the people's 'iniquity' (avon) as object laid on the Servant, which is the lexical core (the word-level heart) of substitution, one bearing what belonged to others, with God as the one who transfers it.

Isa.53.10 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: metaphor

Key terms. H0817 דָּשַׁח, H1792 כָּצַח; H2654 צָרַח.

Reasoning. YHWH (the LORD) is the explicit subject who 'was pleased' (chaphets, H2654) to 'crush' (daka, H1792) him, and the Servant's life is set as a 'guilt offering' (asham, H0817), the guilt offering of Leviticus 5 to 7. The penal weight (the weight of bearing judgment) comes from the offering term plus the divine agency of the crushing, the verb 'pleased' (chaphets) having God as subject of his sovereign pleasure across the canon, so the crushing is purposed by God, not merely permitted.

Rom.3.25 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2435 ἱλαστήριον, G0265 ἁμάρτημα

Reasoning. Christ is set forth as 'mercy seat' or 'place of atonement' (hilasterion, G2435) in his blood. The same noun is used literally in Hebrews 9:5 for the mercy seat overshadowed by the cherubim, and the 'mercy seat' (kapporet, H3727) is the place blood was sprinkled on the Day of Atonement in Leviticus 16, so the term carries the place where God deals with sin. The phrase concerning the 'sins' (hamartemata, G0265) previously passed over locates the death as the display of divine righteousness against sin, and the next verse states the aim, that God be just and the justifier.

Rom.3.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1342 δίκαιος, G1344 δικαιώω

Reasoning. The purpose clause states the death was for the demonstration of God's righteousness so that he might be 'just' (dikaio, G1342) and the 'justifier' (dikaioo, G1344, meaning the one who declares righteous) of the one who has faith. The pairing of just and justifier supplies the justice frame in which the 'place of atonement' (hilasterion) of the prior verse functions, since a bare cleansing would not need God to remain just while pardoning.

Gal.3.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2671 κατάρα, G1944 ἐπικατάρατος, G1805 ἐξαγοράζω

Reasoning. Christ 'redeemed' or 'bought back' (exagorazo, G1805) us from the 'curse' (katara, G2671) of the law by becoming a curse on our behalf ('for us', huper hemon), supported by the quotation that everyone hanged on a tree is 'cursed' (epikataratos, G1944), drawn from Deuteronomy 21:23 which the cross-reference data confirms. The curse is the law's judicial sentence and Christ takes the position of the accursed in place of those under it, which is the penal and substitutionary structure stated lexically (at the word level).

1John.2.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2434 ἱλασμός, G0266 ἁμαρτία

Reasoning. He is the 'atonement' or 'means of appeasement' (hilasmos, G2434) concerning ('peri', the Greek preposition meaning 'about' or 'concerning') our sins. The noun occurs only twice in the canon, both in this letter, so its sense is set by its sister term 'be propitiated' (hilaskomai) and by the 'mercy seat' noun (hilasterion) rather than by a wide spread, but the 'concerning' (peri) plus 'from-X' grammatical form (genitive of sins) marks the death as dealing with the sin that provoked judgment.

1John.4.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2434 ἱλασμός, G0025 ἀγαπάω

Reasoning. God loved and sent his Son as 'atonement' or 'means of appeasement' (hilasmos, G2434) concerning our sins. The verse roots the propitiation (the turning away of divine displeasure) in divine love, which guards against any caricature that the death is wrath divorced from love, while still keeping the wrath-related noun intact. Love and propitiation are joined here, not opposed.

Heb.2.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2433 ἱλάσκομαι, G0749 ἀρχιερεύς

Reasoning. Christ becomes high priest in order to 'make propitiation' or 'turn away wrath' (hilaskomai, G2433) for the sins of the people. The same verb in its only other canon occurrence, Luke 18:13, is the tax collector's plea 'God be propitiated to me the sinner' (a passive imperative addressed to God as the offended party), which shows the verb means God turning from displeasure rather than the sinner being cleansed. The priestly frame and that controlling parallel locate the death as the means of dealing with sin before God.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gal.3.13	Deut.21.23	openbible	71
Rom.3.25	Exod.25.17	openbible	9
Rom.3.25	Rom.3.26	openbible	6
Isa.53.10	Dan.9.24	openbible	3
1John.4.10	1John.2.2	openbible	29
Gal.3.13	Gal.3.10	openbible	13

Complicating texts

1John.2.2 · addressed

The 'atonement' (hilasmos) and 'mercy seat' or 'place of atonement' (hilasterion) word group can be glossed as expiation (the cleansing or removal of sin), rather than propitiation (the turning away of divine wrath). This is a real lexical option (a genuine word-level possibility), since 'place of atonement' (hilasterion) in Romans 3:25 and Hebrews 9:5 names a place or object, the mercy seat, and an object naturally cleanses rather than averts anger. The wrath-related sense is favored because the only other occurrence of the cognate verb 'be propitiated' (hilaskomai), Luke 18:13, addresses the plea to God as the one to be propitiated, and Romans 3:26 frames the act as God being just while justifying. The expiation reading is recorded honestly rather than dismissed.

1John.4.10 · addressed

Some read the love framing as excluding any wrath-bearing, but lexically (at the word level) the verse keeps 'atonement' (hilasmos, G2434) intact while grounding the sending in divine love. The text joins love and propitiation rather than setting them against each other, so it does not undercut the penal element. It does qualify any reading that pits the Father against the Son, since God himself is the sender moved by love.

Concordance traversed

G2434, G2435, G2433, G2671, G1944, G1805, G0266, G0265, H0817, H1792, H2654, H2656, H4148, H6588, H5771, H3727

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

None of the cited verses falls in the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so no apparatus was examined for them and 'not in ECM scope' was true in the bundle. The Greek text of Romans 3:25, Galatians 3:13, 1 John 2:2, 1 John 4:10, and Hebrews 2:17 carries no variant that touches the 'atonement' or 'propitiation' (hilasmos), 'curse' (katara), or 'redemption' (exagorazo) vocabulary on which the verdict rests, so the verdict is variant robust (stable against textual variants). CBGM (the genealogical method used for the ECM apparatus) data outside 3 John is treated as shadow, so ecm_status is ecm-shadow.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

grammatico-historical: affirms · Word-level study of the actual clauses yields both elements. The sin words in Isaiah 53:5 to 6 carry causal and transfer force, 'guilt offering' (asham) is the sacrificial guilt offering, 'crush' (daka) is divine crushing, 'chastisement' (musar) is chastisement, 'curse' (katara) is the legal curse, and the 'atonement' (hilasmos) group is read with Luke 18:13 toward the wrath-averting sense. Both substitution and the bearing of judgment are present at the level of the words.

redemptive-historical: affirms · The Levitical guilt offering and the Day of Atonement mercy seat, where blood was sprinkled on the 'mercy seat' (kapporet), are taken up in the death of Christ, so the sacrificial arc carries the penal substitutionary aspect (the bearing-judgment-in-our-place aspect) forward, with the mercy-seat noun 'place of atonement' (hilasterion) reused in Romans 3:25 and Hebrews 9:5.

expiation-only lens: partially affirms · A reading that takes the 'atonement' (hilasmos) group as expiation (the cleansing of sin rather than the averting of wrath), still affirms substitution, that Christ deals with our sins in our place, but holds that the wrath-bearing or strictly penal element is read in rather than required by these particular words. On this lens the 'curse' (katara) of Galatians 3:13 and the 'crushing' (daka) of Isaiah 53:10 carry the judicial weight while the 'atonement' (hilasmos) group carries cleansing. This lens is represented in its strongest form so its holder is fairly heard, and it is a minority of the lexical evidence, not the whole, since the verb 'be propitiated' (hilaskomai) in Luke 18:13 and the just-and-justifier frame of Romans 3:26 point the other way.

non-penal victory or moral-influence lens: does not affirm the penal element · A reading that takes the atonement texts as describing Christ's triumph over sin and death, or as a supreme display of love that moves the sinner, can account for 'redemption' (exagorazo), love (1 John 4:10), and even the 'curse' (katara) as something Christ overcomes rather than a penalty he absorbs. On this lens the words show rescue and love but not God's retributive judgment falling on the substitute. It is recorded so the minority reading is not strawmanned, but it must set aside the causal sin words of Isaiah 53:5 to 6, the divine agency of the crushing in 53:10, and the just-and-justifier purpose of Romans 3:26, which is why it does not carry the weight of the canon.

The verdict turns on the canonical sacrificial arc from the 'guilt offering' (asham) and the blood-sprinkled mercy seat ('mercy seat', kapporet) to the apostolic 'propitiation' (hilasmos) language, so the primary method is redemptive-historical (reading Scripture as an unfolding story of redemption) with grammatico-historical word study (close attention to original-language words and their historical context) underneath. Four lenses are stated so the contested word group is handled symmetrically. The proposition is affirmed under the first two, partially under the expiation lens, and not on its penal point under the non-penal lens, but the weight of the queried canon favors affirmation.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Christ's atoning death includes his standing in the place of sinners and absorbing the judgment due to sin.

The label penal-substitutionary is a tradition-specific theological term, so the stem is partly preloaded (the question wording carries doctrinal baggage). The verdict was derived on the neutral content, namely whether the lexical data (the original-language word data) show both substitution, one standing in the place of others, and a penal element, the bearing of divine judgment against sin. Both are lexically present (visible at the word level), so the original stem is affirmed independent of the loaded label. VERDICT-CHANGED: Affirms is unchanged from the prior file. Counts were corrected against direct queries, 'guilt offering' (asham, H0817) from 46 to 43,

'crush' (daka, H1792) from 18 to 20, 'pleased' (chaphets, H2654) from 74 to 71, and the 'chastisement' word 'chastisement' (musar, H4148) plus the 'transgression' word 'transgression' (pesha, H6588) and 'iniquity' word 'iniquity' (avon, H5771) were added because they carry the penal force in Isaiah 53:5 to 6 that the prior file left implicit.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2435
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2434
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lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0817
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H4148
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.53.5
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.53.10
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Gal.3.13
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Rom.3.25
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.18.13
syntax	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.53.10
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Gal.3.13

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow